

Michael Bulkaam Shikpan

he/him/his

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EDUCATION

2025–Present	PhD in Linguistics Department of Linguistics, University of Toronto Toronto, Canada
2024–2025	M.A. in Linguistics Department of Linguistics, University of Toronto Toronto, Canada Thesis: <i>Assimilation, Epenthesis and Rounding Harmony in Tal Reduplicated Verb Focus</i> Supervisor: Professor Samuel Akinbo
2020–2022	M.A. in Language Documentation and Description Department of Linguistics and Translation, Theological College of Northern Nigeria Bukuru-Jos, Nigeria Thesis: <i>Plural Verbs in Tal in the Context of West Chadic Languages</i> Supervisor: Dr. Matthew Harley
2013–2017	B.A. in Linguistics and Translation Department of Linguistics and Translation, Theological College of Northern Nigeria, affiliated with the University of Jos Bukuru-Jos, Nigeria Second Class Upper Division Thesis: <i>Tense and Aspect in Tal</i> Supervisor: Dr. Matthew Harley
2009–2011	A-Level IJMB, Arts and Languages Department of Basic and Remedial Studies, Nasarawa State Polytechnic Lafia, Nigeria

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Language documentation; phonology; phonetics; tone; morphotonology; vowel harmony; phonology–morphosyntax interface; lexicography; Chadic and West Chadic languages; under-documented African languages.

RESEARCH GRANTS, CONTRACTS, AND AWARDS

2025–2026	Phonology Prize Award for Outstanding Research Paper. Department of Linguistics, University of Toronto. Awarded for research on Tal phonology, especially rounding harmony in Tal.
2025	Frances Dichter Graduate Scholarship in Linguistics. University of Toronto. CAD 10,000.

- 2024** **Nominated Final Proposal for the Ambassadors Fund for Cultural Preservation.** U.S. Government. USD 270,000.
 Title: *Inventory, Documentation and Conservation of Intangible Cultural Heritage in the Middle Belt, Nigeria*.
 Role: Co-author. PI: Professor Aaron Carter-Enyi.
<https://pressbooks.pub/middlebelt/>
- 2024** **Frances Dichter Graduate Scholarship in Linguistics.** University of Toronto. CAD 10,000.
- 2023** **Interviews on Farmer-Herder Conflict in Nigeria.** Morehouse College Environmental Justice and Sustainability Program. USD 2,000. PI: Professor Aaron Carter-Enyi.
- 2023** **Documentation of Cara: An Endangered Central Plateau Language of Nigeria.** Endangered Language Fund. USD 3,210. Role: Principal Investigator.
- 2023–2025** **Harmony System in Yebu.** Department of Linguistics, University of Toronto. USD 3,700. PI: Professor Avery Ozburn.

PUBLICATIONS

- Akinbo, Samuel, Tongpan Rabo Fwangwar, and **Michael Bulkaam**. Submitted. Morphophonological tonal polarity in West Chadic languages. *Phonology*.
- Akinbo, Samuel, and **Michael Bulkaam**. 2024. Iconicity as the motivation for the signification and locality of deictic grammatical tones in Tal. *Glossa: A Journal of General Linguistics* 9(1), 1–41. DOI: 10.16995/glossa.10666.
- Bulkaam, Michael**, and Roger Blench. In press. *Dictionary of Tal: A West Chadic Language of Nigeria*. Submitted to Rüdiger Köppe Verlag, Germany.
- Bulkaam, Michael**, and Roger Blench. 2021. Reconstructing economic history through linguistics: A case study from the A3 West Chadic languages in Central Nigeria. Paper submitted for the proceedings of the International and Interdisciplinary Conference on African Pre-Colonial History.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

- Bulkaam, Michael**. In preparation. *Grammatical Tone in Tal: Evidence from Tense and Subjunctive Mood*.
- Akinbo, Samuel, Pedro Mateo Pedro, and **Michael Bulkaam**. In preparation. *A Pedagogical Grammar of Tal*.
- Akinbo, Samuel, and **Michael Bulkaam**. In preparation. Tal gerundive formation. To be submitted to *Languages*.
- Akinbo, Samuel, and **Michael Bulkaam**. In preparation. Analysis of the tone system in Tal.
- Ozburn, Avery, and **Michael Bulkaam**. In preparation. Harmony system in Yebu.
- Ozburn, Avery, and **Michael Bulkaam**. In preparation. Yebu vowel system.

UNPUBLISHED MANUSCRIPTS

- Blench, Roger, and **Michael Bulkaam**. 2021. *An Introduction to Mantsi, a South Bauchi Language of Central Nigeria*. Prepublication.
- Blench, Roger, and **Michael Bulkaam**. 2020. *A Preliminary Lexicon of Teel [= Tehl, Montol]: An Under-Documented Language of Central Nigeria*. Prepublication.

- Blench, Roger, **Michael Bulkaam**, and Simon Gyepya. 2019. *The Decennial Magic Show: The Religious System of the Tal of Central Nigeria*. Unpublished manuscript.
- Blench, Roger, and **Michael Bulkaam**. 2019a. *Belnang, an Undocumented Chadic Language of Central Nigeria*. Prepublication.
- Blench, Roger, and **Michael Bulkaam**. 2019b. *Jibyal, an Undocumented Chadic Language of Central Nigeria*. Unpublished manuscript.
- Blench, Roger, and **Michael Bulkaam**. 2019c. *Jakato, an Under-Documented Language of Central Nigeria*. Unpublished manuscript.
- Blench, Roger, and **Michael Bulkaam**. 2019d. *Nteng, an Undocumented Language of Central Nigeria*. Unpublished manuscript.
- Blench, Roger, and **Michael Bulkaam**. 2017. *Ethnozoology of the Tal, Chadic Speakers of West-Central Nigeria*. Unpublished manuscript.

PRESENTATIONS

Guest Talks

- Bulkaam, Michael**. October 26, 2023. Reduplication in Tal: An A3 West Chadic language. Graduate seminar, University of Toronto. Instructor: Assistant Professor Samuel Akinbo.

Contributed Presentations

- Bulkaam, Michael**. February 27, 2026. The tonal system of Tal: Evidence from lexical contrast and morphotonological alternations. Language Description, Documentation and Revitalization Group, University of Toronto.
- Aaron Carter-Enyi, Ebruphiyor Omodoro, and **Michael Bulkaam**. October 23–26, 2025. Intangible cultural heritage of Nigeria's Middle Belt. Society for Ethnomusicology Annual Meeting, Marriott Marquis Downtown Hotel, Atlanta, Georgia.
- Bulkaam, Michael**, and Samuel Akinbo. May 15–17, 2025. Vowel harmony in Tal: Evidence from verb reduplication. Association of Contemporary African Linguistics 56, University of Minnesota. Online.
- Natasha Vujicic, Alyssa Cas Duarte Vorobey, **Michael Bulkaam**, and Samuel Akinbo. May 15–17, 2025. Acoustic evidence in support of floating as the target of lexical grammatical tones in Tal. Association of Contemporary African Linguistics 56, University of Minnesota. Online.
- Akinbo, Samuel, and **Michael Bulkaam**. October 21–22, 2023. Grammaticalised iconicity, deixis, and phonological locality in Tal. Annual Meeting on Phonology. Poster. Online.
- Bulkaam, Michael**. October 15–19, 2023. The exotic phonology of Ywom (Chadic) and implications for orthography development. Conference of the Linguistic Association of Nigeria, Federal University Lokoja, Kogi State, Nigeria.
- Blench, Roger, Saul Samuel, and **Michael Bulkaam**. September 13–15, 2023. An extended morphosyntax of Bəna-Yungur noun classes. Second Adamawa Conference, Paris. Online.
- Bulkaam, Michael**. 2022. Plural verbs in Tal in the context of West Chadic languages. Eleventh Biennial International Colloquium on the Chadic Languages, University of Vienna, Austria. Online.
- Bulkaam, Michael**. 2021. Plural verbs in A3 West Chadic languages. Jos Linguistic Circle, Jos, Nigeria.

- Bulkaam, Michael.** 2021. A morphological analysis of verbal pluralisation in Teel [Montol]. Interdisciplinary seminar presentation, Theological College of Northern Nigeria, Bukuru-Jos, Nigeria.
- Bulkaam, Michael.** 2021. A morphological analysis of plural verbs in Tal (West Chadic). Tenth World Congress of African Linguistics, Leiden University, Netherlands. Online.
- Bulkaam, Michael.** 2021. Reconstructing economic history through linguistics: A case study from the A3 West Chadic languages in Central Nigeria. International and Interdisciplinary Conference on African Pre-Colonial History, Université libre de Bruxelles, Belgium. Online.
- Bulkaam, Michael.** 2019. Tense in Tal narratives. Conference of the Linguistic Association of Nigeria, Customs Command and Staff College Gwagwalada/University of Abuja, Nigeria.
- Bulkaam, Michael.** 2017. Recent consonant discoveries in Tal. Jos Linguistic Circle, Jos, Nigeria.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

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| 2024–Present | Teaching Assistant. Department of Linguistics, University of Toronto, Toronto, Canada.
Courses: <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • JAL401H1/JAL1145HF/LIN458H1S – Field Methods in Linguistics • LIN303H – Central American Indigenous Language • LIN200 – Introduction to Language • LIN201 – English Grammar |
| 2021–2022 | Graduate Assistant Lecturer. Department of Linguistics and Translation, Theological College of Northern Nigeria, Bukuru-Jos, Nigeria.
Course: <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • LLL 205 – Word Collection |
| 2020–2022 | Instructor. The Word for the World Nigeria Initiative, Abuja, Nigeria.
Courses: <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Orthography • Lexicography |

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

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| July –Dec 2026 | Research Assistant. Afrocentric Natural Language Processing.
PI: Professor Ife Adebare. University of Alberta. |
| May 2026 | Research Assistant. Tal Pedagogical Grammar Project.
Supervisor: Professor Pedro Mateo Pedro. University of Toronto. |
| 2025–2026 | Research Assistant. Counting and Measuring in Gã and Yoruba: Evidence from the Documentation of Food Culture in Ghana, Nigeria, and the African Diaspora in the GTA.
PIs: Professors Samuel Akinbo and Suzi Lima. University of Toronto. |
| 2022–Present | Research Assistant. Studies in Chadic Languages.
PI: Professor Samuel Akinbo. University of Toronto. |
| 2023–2025 | Research Assistant. Harmony System.
PI: Professor Avery Ozburn. University of Toronto. |

2018–2020 **Research Consultant.** Documentation of Nigerian Languages.
Employer: Dr. Roger Blench, Kay Williamson Educational Foundation, Gold and Base, Rayfield-Jos, Nigeria.

MENTORSHIP AND ACADEMIC ADVISING

2023–Present **Research Mentor, Linguistics. Nigeria/Remote.**

Provide informal academic mentorship to emerging linguists and language researchers in Nigerian linguistics institutions and language development programs, with a focus on heritage language documentation, transcription, tone marking, dictionary development, pedagogical grammar development, data organization, linguistic analysis, and academic writing.

- **Nankam Julius Shwandik.** 400-Level Student, Department of Linguistics and Translation, Theological College of Northern Nigeria.
Mentorship focus: Dictionary development, including guidance on transcription and tone marking accuracy, research design, data analysis, and academic writing.
- **Kanba Danjuma.** Language Adviser, Graceland Church of Beatitude Translation, Jos, Nigeria.
Mentorship focus: Language documentation and pedagogical grammar development, including transcription, glossing, and presentation of linguistic data.

FIELDWORK EXPERIENCE

2025	Conducted fieldwork in Tal for the elicitation of Tal music surrogate data.
2024	Conducted lexical data collection and dictionary development for Ganang, Gyem, Gura, Jakun, Sigidi, and Fyalu.
2023–2024	Conducted fieldwork language documentation project for Cara.
2023	Conducted fieldwork in Tal for the recording of acoustic, tonal, and narrative data.
2023	Conducted word collection on Bata, a Central Chadic language of Adamawa State, and iTunzu, a Kainji language.
2023	Conducted Yebu data collection fieldwork in Kaltungo, Bauchi State, Nigeria.
2023	Carried out dictionary consultant checking for Nyankpa and Ishe, Plateau State, Nigeria.
2022–2023	Conducted fieldwork and documentation on eBoze.
2022	Conducted fieldwork in Tal for text collection for discourse studies at the Theological College of Northern Nigeria.
2021	Conducted fieldwork in Ribina, Loro, and Panawa communities in Toro LGA, Bauchi State, on Bunu and Panawa, Eastern Kainji languages.
2019	Conducted fieldwork in Zul, Buk/Zaranda, Bolu, Dokshi, and Mantsi, Bauchi State, Nigeria.
2019	Conducted fieldwork in Chakfem and Ywom, Chadic languages of Plateau State, Nigeria.
2019	Conducted fieldwork in Tel and Miship, Chadic languages of Plateau State, Nigeria.
2019	Conducted fieldwork in Gera, Bauchi State, Nigeria.

2019	Conducted fieldwork in Tal, Plateau State, Nigeria.
2018	Conducted fieldwork in Gera, Bauchi State, Nigeria.
2017	Conducted fieldwork in Tal, Pyanpung, Koenom, Belning, and Jakato.
2016	Participated in TCNN phonology and grammar fieldwork in Tal.
2015	Conducted TCNN fieldwork, word collection, text collection, and sociolinguistic survey in Tal.

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

2024	Teaching Assistants' Training Program, Discussion-Based Tutorial. Participant. University of Toronto.
2024	Teaching Assistants' Training Program, Problem Sets Tutorial. Participant. University of Toronto.
2022	Global Partnerships Field Coordinators' Training. Participant from Nigeria. Bible Translation and Literacy, Nairobi, Kenya.
2021	Africana Digital Ethnography Project Training. Participant. University of Nigeria, Nsukka.
2006	Introductory Course in Applied Linguistics. Participant. Nigerian Bible Translation Trust, Jos, Nigeria.

WORK AND PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

2024–Present	Research and Teaching Assistant. Department of Linguistics, University of Toronto, Canada.
2018–Present	Research Consultant. Kay Williamson Educational Foundation, Gold and Base, Rayfield-Jos, Plateau State, Nigeria.
2023–Present	Field Coordinator/Partnership Facilitator. Global Partnerships, Anglophone-Lusophone Africa Area. Serving with NBTT, Jos, Plateau State, Nigeria.
2023–Present	Volunteer Literacy Coordinator. Tal Language Development Project, Jos, Plateau State, Nigeria.
2022–Present	Researcher and Interviewer. Farmer-herder conflicts in Central Nigeria. Africana Digital Ethnography Project, Morehouse College, Atlanta, USA.
2021–2022	Graduate Assistant Lecturer. Department of Linguistics and Translation, Theological College of Northern Nigeria, Bukuru-Jos, Plateau State, Nigeria.
2017–2019	Linguist, Language Documenter, and Facilitator. CAPRO Translation Department, National Headquarters, Jos, Nigeria.
2006–2020	Volunteer Literacy Instructor. Tal Communities, Tal District/Tal Youths Association, Jos Branch, Nigeria.

LANGUAGE SKILLS

Tal: Native

Hausa: Advanced

English: Advanced

Nigerian Pidgin: Advanced

Ngas: Intermediate

Chakfem: Intermediate

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Speech Analysis: Praat; Speech Analyzer

Annotation and Documentation: ELAN; FLEx; SayMore; ParaText

Text Processing and Typesetting: Microsoft Word; Excel; PowerPoint; LaTeX

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

2025–Present	The Canadian Linguistic Association.
2025–Present	Association of Contemporary African Linguistics.
2025–Present	The Society for Ethnomusicology.
2023–Present	Linguistic Association of Nigeria.

REFERENCES

Dr. Samuel Akinbo

Assistant Professor of Linguistics
Department of Linguistics, University of Toronto
Email: samuel.akinbo@utoronto.ca

Dr. Avery Ozburn

Assistant Professor of Linguistics
Department of Linguistics, University of Toronto
Email: avery.ozburn@utoronto.ca

Dr. Pedro Mateo Pedro

Assistant Professor
Department of Linguistics, University of Toronto
Email: pedro.mateo@utoronto.ca
Relationship: Instructor for courses where I served as Teaching Assistant.